of these facilities. Besides, we loved the Sunday tombola and brunch, whose menu was simple and wholesome and alternated between biryani, dosa or chana bhatura and a dessert. We also looked forward to the weekly movies shown outdoors on the noisy projector system. Whenever the film reel finished, there would be a short break while the operator replaced it. We grew up watching movies like *To Hell and Back, Gone with the Wind, From Here to Eternity* and *Ben Hur*. Most of them highlighted courage, comradeship, patriotism and other qualities of warriors, and were an important factor in motivating us to choose the army as a career. There were other social functions like the New Year's Eve or the May Queen Ball. However, in those days, children were not permitted to attend them.

The annual sports meet of the station was a great hit with the kids. The march past, relay races and the sprints were most exciting and we would lustily cheer our dad's team. The tug of war was always the last event, extremely prestigious, and thus hotly contested. The grand finale was the band display, capped by the beating of the retreat and high tea. Our sights by then would be set on goodies like chocolate pastries, samosas and gulab jamuns. To access the best delicacies we had to sneak into the enclosures meant for senior officers and do a quick job. All said and done, it was a healthy and simple life that we led.

Transfers of my father were fun occasions, too. Those were the days of steam engines, and the trains moved at a snail's pace. I remember the long journey of two or three days from Jhansi to Secunderabad. Ours being a large family, dad was entitled to a whole first-class compartment. During the Raj period, such compartments were reserved for the whites. The carriage had three cushioned berths and three bunks above them. There were nice lights and small but noisy fans on the ceiling. We would make it our temporary home. In summer, the compartment got very hot, and to keep it cool the railways provided us huge tubs with slabs of ice. These ice slabs were replaced only at big junction stations. It was not a very effective solution but there was no alternative. Because of the heat, we travelled wearing nothing except our shorts. Food